

Loudspeakers are of two types – dynamic and electrostatic the latter use a high-voltage electric field rather than a magnetic field to drive a membrane rather than a voice coil

Headphones are miniature speakers and can be either electrostatic or dynamic

TRIED & TESTED

Audio Engine A2 + S8 = Aural Nirvana?



The Audio Engine A2 is rather impressive though obviously it lacks bass. Meet its significant other – the S8 – a mean looking woofer unit with an eight-inch driver. The footpegs are two inches long and this ensures adequate distance between the driver and the floor. There are adjustments for bass level, phase and crossover threshold. The latter is adjustable from 30 Hz all the way to 150 Hz. Although the A2 has its own amplifier built into it when connected to the S8, this amplifier is fed by the amplifier of the S8 and the output from the soundcard is now connected to the woofer unit instead of the satellites. Priced at Rs 10,400 for the A2 and a whopping Rs 24,400 for the S8, this combo is very expensive for even a music lover.

The A5 in conjunction with the S8 would be pricier still. Once we set up the A2s with the S8 woofer unit we were surprised at the amount of bass this unit produces. It's not really boomy unless the volume level is really pushed, though to be honest, it's not as good as some of the other top-end woofers we've come across. The bass is clean, goes low and has a very pleasing impact. Explosions sound frightfully real. The woofer is powerful enough to do a slow dance if the volume is turned up – this is a pity. The A2, now free of its burden with producing great lows with its puny drivers can now focus on the highs and the mid-range which for some is where all the emotion in the music lies. Together this setup demolishes most other speaker setups easily. If anything, the woofer is overpowering and we figure the A5 speakers would be slightly more suited to such a powerful low frequency unit. The price still worries us. For Rs 50,000 or thereabouts you could pick up a great amplifier and floorstander combo which would demolish the A2 and the S8.

T-9000; but at Rs 10,400, the A2 is much costlier than the T-9000 which, at Rs 3,300 shocked us. It's great-looking barring a few oddities, sounds really good and at its price will likely find a lot of takers. If you're looking for a set of 2.0 speakers and have a gigantic table you can close your eyes and reach for your wallet. In case you want something really compact and yet no compromise on quality, you need to shell out big time for the Audio Engine A2. Casual music listeners who want something small and funky looking will be satisfied with the Altec Lansing FX 2020 – although really once you consider the ZEB T-9000 – nothing in the 2.0 speaker category is good value for money.

2.1 SPEAKERS

Look ma, I got a woofer too

Music lovers will want to take a look at this category closely. This is because with the presence of a larger enclosure with a larger driver unit dedicated to reproducing the

lower frequency range (25 Hz to 150 Hz) properly, a 2.1 system gives you the best music experience possible. Obviously, no two 2.1 speaker systems are equal and just having a 2.1 system does not guarantee music quality. We were tempted to test the combination of the Audio Engine A2 and S8 woofer in this category, but refrained since both these units can be purchased separately. One of things that is very important is the control over the bass of the woofer unit via a control knob and we looked for this feature.

Features:

We had a huge range of 2.1 speakers this time round and there were some 15 speakers in this category. From the outset, these were a diverse bunch and this was no more apparent than in the looks department. First, the tank-like, alien spaceship looking oval Razer Mako that seemed like it would survive a toss out the window (but probably won't, so refrain!). Both the Zebronic speakers looked good – the Duality 5000 and Duality 6000 will both turn heads and get more than cursory glances, although the latter is probably the better looking of the two. Both these speakers have some sort of design embossed into the front surface and the Duality 6000 has a very retro looking set of three matte finished dials – one each for volume, treble and bass. The woofer unit on both these speakers sets has two drivers hence the moniker, Duality. The build quality is good and kudos to Zebronic to come up with such a neat design. The Artis S-Dual uses the same enclosures as the Duality 5000 and aside from the brand name and graphics used, these speakers look identical. The Altec Lansing VS2421 is also attractive with a black-and-maroon colour combo that looks stylish and expensive. The remote unit is also well designed. The speaker grilles are a good quality cloth and the satin finish looks outstanding. The Intex IT2600 was boldly different and the entire set had a silver finish, while other vendors stuck to evergreen black. The Umax UPB 3200 was another neat looking unit. The woofer unit is small but looks neat

EDITOR'S PICK
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Zebronic Duality 5000